

- How to live within your means
- How to reduce expenses
- Common excuses to resisting cutting expenses
- Distinguishing between a want and a need
- Creating a budget and tracking where your money goes
- Identifying your spending priorities
- Keeping up with the Joneses
- It's not how much you make
- Establishing goals

Give Things Up? Never!

I remember reading an article about a popular television series. The characters in this show were young adults with jobs that ranged from bartender to lifeguard to aspiring actor. None of them were making great money but they somehow managed to share a large beach house in Malibu Beach, California. The article went on to show that taking into consideration a typical rent payment in this community, in addition to the furniture, clothes, and cars they drove, it would be impossible for the characters to pay for these things on their salaries.

Unfortunately, many viewers believed it was normal to live in this manner. Comparing our lives to those on television, or the lives of our coworkers or friends, can create unrealistic expectations. By first determining the lifestyle that you would like before finding out what lifestyle you can afford, you run the risk that the money you have will not match the vision. John and Sue White took that risk.

The Whites had a gorgeous view of the ocean from their penthouse apartment in Manhattan Beach, California. All it took was \$2,500 a month in rent, plus some hefty payments for their leased luxury cars, to appear like they were living the high life. Their friends believed it too, since they could also

